Labelled bases

Coefficient-labelled factor bases are generic: a 2√N lower bound

2026-10-26 · item 3 of the 2026-10-26 triage (`docs/session-logs/2026-10-26.md`) · **class: derivation (no measurement, no leaderboard row).** Graph `bound.svg` (`plot.py`; it evaluates the closed-form bound below, nothing measured) · PDF `report.pdf`.

The idea examined

Construct the factor base from labelled points `R_i = a_i G + b_i Q`, so that a **single** decomposition of a labelled target `T = aG + bQ` over the base, `T = Σ ε_j R_{i_j}`, solves the discrete log whenever the `Q`-coefficients do not cancel. That removes the linear-algebra phase and the need for a full-rank matrix. The baseline already stops at the first dependency (`ic_framework/linalg.rs`, incremental Gauss pins the target column). What is new here is labelling the base itself.

Model

- `N`: group order. `S ⊂ G` is a structured set of size `s` whose decompositions an oracle can find (small abscissae, a coset, a tower base…).
- A labelled point is useful only inside `S`, because decompositions are over `S`. Labelled points come from draws `aG + bQ`, each at least one group operation. Unless the structure maps labels into `S` (see "Exceptions"), a draw lands in `S` with probability `s/N`. So a labelled base of `B ≤ s` points costs **at least `B·N/s`**.
- A target has on average `s^m/(m!·N)` decompositions into `m` points of `S`. The oracle pays at least one operation per target and at least one per decomposition it returns: **cost ≥ `max(1, s^m/(m!·N))` per target**.
- A decomposition is useful only if all `m` points are labelled, which happens with probability `(B/s)^m`. The expected number of useful decompositions per target is then `B^m/(m!·N)`, so **about `m!·N/B^m` targets** are needed.

Bound

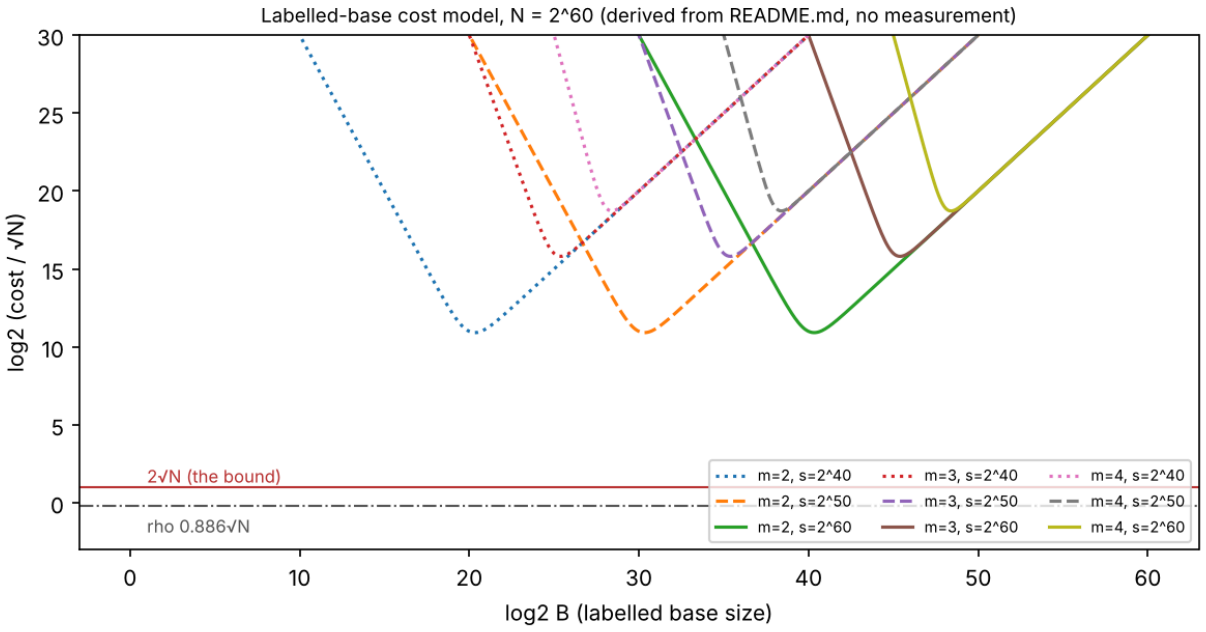
Total cost `C ≥ B·N/s + (m!·N/B^m)·max(1, s^m/(m!·N))`.

- If `s^m ≥ m!·N`: `C ≥ B·N/s + s^m/B^m ≥ 2·√(N·(s/B)^{m−1}) ≥ 2√N`, since `B ≤ s`.
- If `s^m < m!·N`: `C ≥ B·N/s + m!·N/B^m ≥ 2·√(m!·N²·B^{1−m}/s) ≥ 2·√(m!·N²/s^m) > 2√N`.

> **Any labelled-base decomposition attack costs at least `2√N` group-operation equivalents, for every structured set `S`, every base size `B ≤ s` and every `m`.** Pollard rho costs about `0.886√N` (`0.627√N` with the negation map), so the labelled base loses to rho by a factor of at least 2.3. It is a constant factor, but it holds for every structure.

The bound is loose. Evaluated at `N = 2^60` (`bound.svg`), the model's minimum over `B` is about `2^11·√N` for `m = 2` and higher for `m = 3, 4`, whatever the size of `S`. Enumerating decompositions over a large `S` is the expensive part.

The other regime: labels without structure. A labelled base can also skip the structured oracle altogether. For example, label `B = N^{1/4}` random points, tabulate their `B²` pair sums, and test targets against the table. That is baby-step giant-step: it uses no structure of `S`, so it is a generic algorithm, and the generic-group lower bound (Shoup, about `√N`) applies; BSGS and rho attain it. Either way, a labelled base is a collision search: with structure it pays the oracle's output, and without structure it is generic.



Exceptions and what they buy

- **Automorphisms.** If `S` is closed under an automorphism group of order `k` whose action on labels is known (negation, `j = 0`/`1728`, Frobenius), one draw labels `k` points of `S`. The bound becomes about `2√(N/k)`. Rho gains the same `√k` from the same automorphisms, so the gap to rho is unchanged.
- **Labels produced by decomposition itself.** Getting labels for all of `S` without sampling is exactly what standard index calculus does: relations plus linear algebra label the base collectively. The labelled-base idea is therefore not an alternative to linear algebra. It replaces linear algebra by sampling, at cost `N/s` per label.
- **Oracles sublinear in their output.** The bound assumes the oracle pays at least one operation per decomposition it returns. An oracle that could test "is there a decomposition entirely inside `L`" for the labelled subset `L` without enumerating would need `L` itself to be structured. A structured `L` of labelled points is the same problem one level down.

Verdict for the triage

Item 3 is **closed by derivation**. With a structured oracle, no setting of `S`, `B` or `m` gets a labelled-base attack below `2√N` (in practice far above it). Without structure the attack is generic and bounded by `√N`. The single-dependency stopping it relies on is already in the baseline. Nothing here is a measured result; the bound is exact under the stated cost model.